TAPE THIS TO THE FRIDGE

The 5-Minute Calm Morning

A tiny routine for the minutes before the kids are up, or right in the middle of the breakfast rush.

> *"Begin the morning by saying to thyself, I shall meet with the busybody, the ungrateful, arrogant, deceitful, envious, unsocial.*
>
> Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 2.1, trans. George Long

Five minutes. Five small steps. Do them while the coffee brews, or in the thick of it. The morning will still be the morning. You just get to meet it on purpose.

1 Name the bumps

1 MINUTE

Name three things that will probably go sideways. The missing shoe. The wrong cup. The oatmeal that was fine yesterday. Say them out loud if you like.

2 Sort two piles

1 MINUTE

Of things some are in our power, and others are not.

Epictetus, Enchiridion 1, trans. George Long

Sort the morning into those two piles. The car line is not yours. Your words are. The weather is not. How you sound in the doorway is. Put down the pile that isn't yours.

3 Later can wait

1 MINUTE

If you're already running the homework fight in your head, the one that hasn't happened yet, leave it. You can have that one later. This morning first.

4 Choose one thing that's yours

1 MINUTE

Pick one thing from your pile and decide, now, how you want to do it. Maybe it's the voice you use when the cup becomes a crisis. Maybe it's a silly joke on the way out the door.

5 Called it

1 MINUTE

When one of those three things happens, and it will, give yourself a small nod. Then keep going. It's hard to be ambushed by something you scheduled.

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